

# Stage 2 — Validation & Product-Market Signals

Timing: Month 2–3 | Objective: Identify the strongest customer, vendor and category patterns

## Primary task

Find the segments and use cases where Shopiva shows the strongest evidence of repeatable demand.

## Funnel analysis

- Map visitors → product viewers → carts → checkout intents → successful payments → delivered orders → repeat purchases.
- Calculate conversion rates at every major step.
- Identify the single biggest bottleneck each month and prioritize it.

## Customer discovery

- Interview customers who purchased, abandoned checkout, cancelled and returned for a second purchase.
- Ask what triggered the purchase, what almost stopped it, what alternatives they considered and what would make them buy again.
- Group customers by behavior rather than assuming one demographic is equally valuable.

## Supply-side validation

- Identify which vendors generate orders and which merely list products.
- Compare categories by sales velocity, margin potential, repeat demand and fulfillment reliability.
- Remove or deprioritize low-quality supply when it harms customer trust.

## Unit economics

- Calculate Shopiva revenue per order after commissions/fees and direct transaction costs.
- Estimate customer acquisition cost (CAC), contribution margin, AOV and repeat purchase behavior.
- Separate GMV from Shopiva revenue and from actual contribution/profit.

## Lean Startup application

- Use innovation accounting: define actionable metrics that reveal whether the business model is improving.
- If evidence contradicts a key assumption, change the product, segment, channel or business model rather than defending the original plan.
- A pivot should be a structured change in strategy while preserving useful learning already acquired.

## Exit criteria

- You can identify the customer segments and categories with the strongest transaction signals.
- The major funnel bottleneck is known.
- You have an initial contribution-margin model.
- There is evidence of at least some repeat behavior or a clear reason why repeat behavior has not yet emerged.

Founder question: Which assumption about customers, vendors or economics has the strongest evidence—and which still depends mainly on belief?

Framework reference: Eric Ries, *The Lean Startup* (Crown Business, 2011). This roadmap applies Lean Startup concepts such as validated learning, the Build–Measure–Learn loop, minimum viable product (MVP), innovation accounting, and pivot/persevere decisions. It does not reproduce the book's text.